But by and large, the Congress party took great efforts to not project itself. This is why leaders such as M.K. Stalin (Tamil Nadu's chief minister), Supriya Sule (parliamentarian) and Aditya Thackeray (former Maharashtra minister) readily joined the Yatra, accepting that inclusivity. Considering the Constitution and the values enshrined in it are under severe attack, this attempt to consciously eliminate partisanship was laudatory. After all, wasn't the purpose of the Yatra to take people from every party and every section along?

People's Experience Within

When movements want to bring people's issues and questions into the political sphere, they face many challenges. It is not just difficult to communicate with leaders, but also challenging to meet them. This impression was reinforced by the fact that some Congress leaders were sceptical about our joining the Yatra (because of our activism against the communal riots in Gujarat and our fight for those displaced by the Narmada Valley Project). They pointed out that 'We are a political party. We have to contest elections,' but Rahul did not seem to take this to heart. Many people's movements insisted on reaching Rahul Gandhi, some even stubbornly so. Meeting any other leader (even if they were former union ministers) could have meant a cursory hearing. So when the interaction finally happened with Rahul, we met him as collective representatives of the campaign to eradicate hatred and to save our Constitution. Many state leaders and stakeholders actively facilitated our meeting (both before and during the Yatra), even though some leaders (and self-appointed civil society leaders) did try to stop us. This mutual competition and opposition between different stakeholders was genuinely funny to us, because it seemed so chaotic. I recall someone joking ironically that Rahul was surrounded by security, but was it to protect him from outside or within? But when we met Rahul, he spoke with ease, cordiality and warmth. That made the whole experience special, and all the smaller issues just vanished.